

Jaswant brought life to the

Finance Bill discussion when he said that tax doles for senior citizens were not enough for even a bottle of whisky.

the first lap of the session.

The prime minister's intervention on Sharm el-Sheikh ensured that there were no political earthquakes but just minor tremors. He borrowed the "Trust but Verify" dictum from Ronald Reagan's quote hanger, who in turn had borrowed—of all people—from Felix Dzerzhinsky, the mastermind of Cheka, the dreaded precursor to KGB. The eco-sensitive denizens definitely found crumbs of satisfaction in Manmohan's speech as he chose to read out from both sides of the paper, not the usual double-spaced one-side sheets. The prime minister's statement didn't evoke a spirited offensive from the BJP, but he kindled the artist in the party's General Secretary Gopinath Munde, who sketched Manmohan on a sheet of paper as he delivered his reply and passed it on to his party colleagues. And Shourie replied to the prime minister with his tongue firmly in cheek: "Verify, then trust".

What diminished the Congress's grand entry were the events that followed the prime minister's statement from Sharm el-Sheikh. The Government stepped on the gas as ally SP demanded the resignation of Petroleum Minister Murli Deora, alleging a Rs 50,000-crore scam in the backdrop of the tussle between the Ambani brothers over gas allocation. The BSP and BJP went on a rampage on the issue of setting up the Bundelkhand

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Development Board, a pet plan of Congress's Rahul Gandhi, without taking the Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh governments into confidence. Members of the Trinamool Congress and Left took each other head on as the former raised the issue of political violence in West Bengal. Constant interruptions and poor homework made an instant dent on the legislative performance of the Government—the

Judges Bill fell on the wayside

and the Right to Education Bill faced flak.

You may question their legislative record, but the MPs are performing public service by making us laugh. While speaking on the progress of the highway projects, Minister for Road Transport and Highways Kamal Nath noted that the years under former prime minister A.B. Vajpayee were "a great learning experience". Seizing the opportunity, AIADMK leader V. Maitreyan said that "the next five years under Manmohan were a great earning experience", in an obvious dig at T.R. Baalu, whose tenure as the minister for road transport had its share of controversies. Jaswant made up for his initial apathy with a brilliant speech while initiating discussions on the Finance Bill. "There are two kinds of finance ministers—those who are found out and those who are kicked out. I am one who got kicked out... by the electorate, which did not bring us back to office....," sending a warning to Pranab Mukherjee to keep the electorate in good humour as "you are also my finance minister". Jaswant brought life to an otherwise drab Finance Bill discussion with his comments that tax doles for senior citizens. "It won't get me even a bottle of whisky," he said. "He should give up (whisky) if he has not already given it up. I myself gave up the habit of smoking pipe," Mukherjee said in his reply. The session also saw CPI(M)'s Brinda Karat fuming as Health Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad repeatedly called her 'Bindra' Karat much to the amusement of the members. Wit and humour should not blind us to the mediocre legacy of the first session that has been turned into a graveyard of key legislations. ■

Brinda...
or Bindra???

